

BETTA FISH · BETTA SPLENDENS

Keep your betta fish the right way from day one.

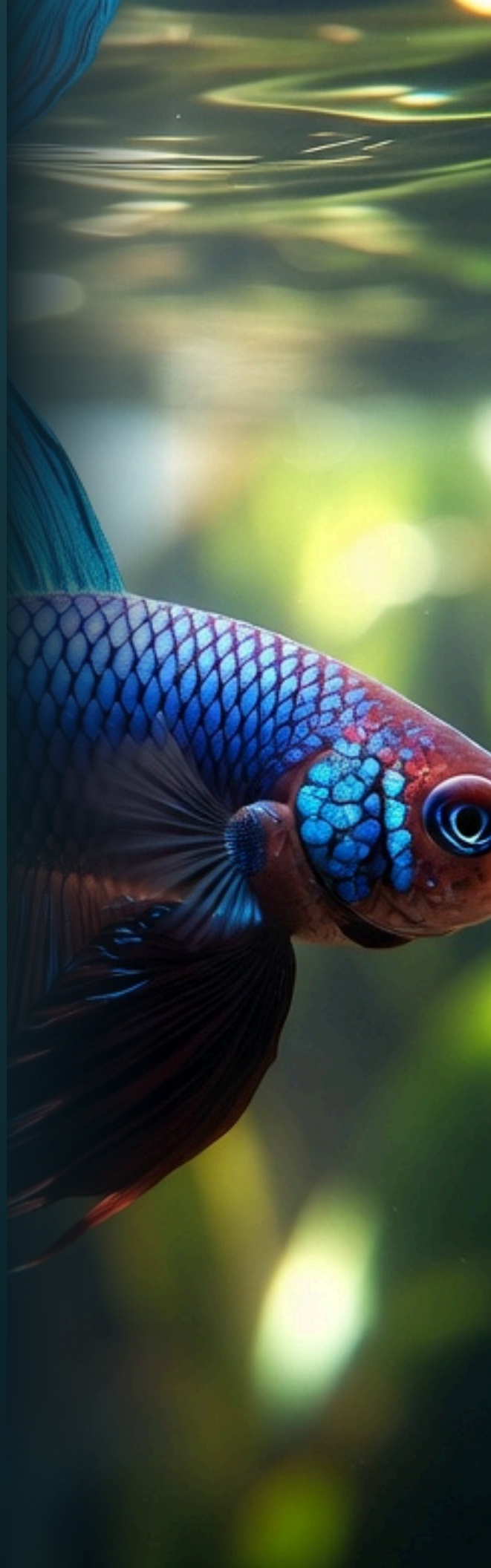
A complete, fact-checked printable manual: tank and equipment, the water numbers that actually matter, health triage, and the routines that keep a betta thriving for its full lifespan.

22 pages

Beginner friendly

Print or tablet

Version 1.0 · Sep 2026



CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
-------------------------	---

SECTION 01 · QUICK PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
-------------------------------	---

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Tank, Heater & Filter	5
Water Parameters That Actually Matter	6
Cycling, Water Changes & Maintenance	7
Diet & Feeding	8
Common Mistakes & Enrichment	9

SECTION 03 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & What to Check First	10
Fin Rot, Ich & Velvet	11
Swim Bladder, Dropsy & Columnaris	12
Stress, Aggression & Tankmates	13

SECTION 04 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Water Targets	14
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	15

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	16
First 30 Days Checklist	17
Symptom Quick Reference	18
Daily & Weekly Routine	19
Owner Log	20
Enrichment Checklist	21

REFERENCE

Glossary	22
----------	----

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order before buying a fish. The tank, the heater, and the cycle are decisions that are hard to undo once a betta is already living in the water, and cycling takes 4 to 6 weeks on its own. Buy the tank first and the fish last, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16.

If your betta is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Water Targets on page 14 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 10 if anything seems off. If your betta is visibly unwell right now, test the water before you buy medication. Page 10 explains why that order almost never changes.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Water Targets | ☐ Page 19: Daily & Weekly Routine |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 18: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 21: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Almost everything sold alongside a betta, the bowl, the unheated kit, the mirror, comes from an outdated picture of the species. This package reflects current standards for tank size, heating, and filtration, plus the peer-reviewed welfare research on page 9, cross-checked against veterinary and aquarium sources rather than the packaging.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An aquatic veterinarian. They are rarer than reptile or small-animal vets, and most betta problems are corrected through water quality rather than treatment, but genuinely serious or unclear cases are still a vet call, not a page in this book.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	Betta splendens, the Siamese fighting fish
Adult size	2.5 to 3 in (6 to 7.5 cm), fins included
Captive lifespan	2 to 4 years, up to 5 with excellent water quality
Native range	Shallow rice paddies, floodplains, and slow streams, Southeast Asia
Diet type	Obligate carnivore; a surface ambush feeder in the wild
Tank minimum (one betta)	5 gallons, heated, gently filtered, and lidded
Handling difficulty	Beginner; observation only, never bare hands
Conservation status	Vulnerable (IUCN), for wild populations

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$100 to \$300 for tank, heater, filter, decor, conditioner, and a liquid test kit. The fish itself is \$5 to \$30, up to about \$55 for rare varieties.

Monthly ongoing

\$20 to \$30 for food, water conditioner, and the electricity to run a heater and filter continuously. Most owners spend \$100 to \$250 a year.

WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY GOES

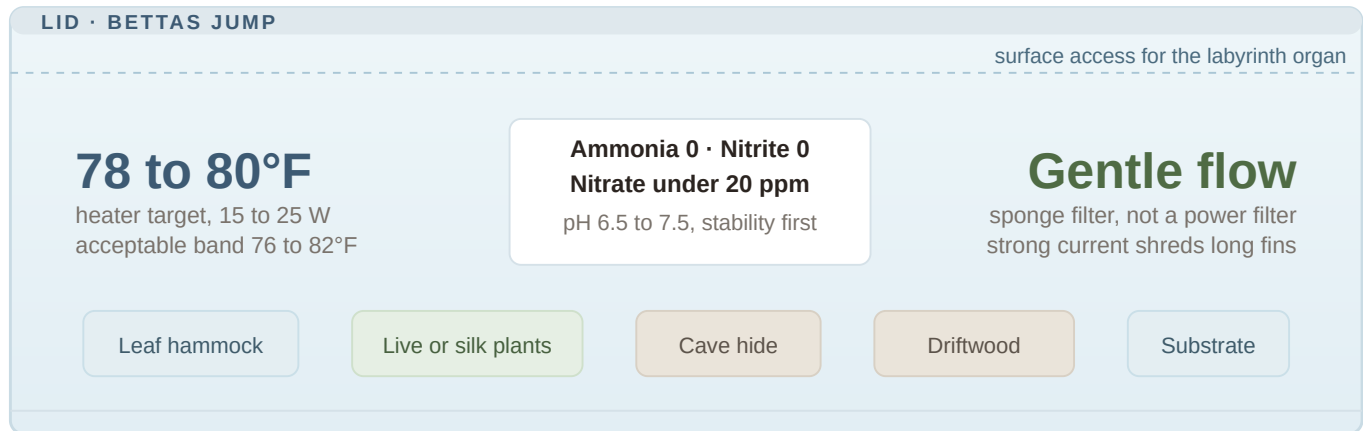
Food is almost never the expensive part. A betta eats a few pellets a day, and food often runs \$30 to \$50 for an entire year. The real recurring cost is running a heater around the clock, which is exactly the item the cheap bowl-and-fish kit leaves out.

Fun facts worth knowing

- They breathe air directly. A labyrinth organ lets a betta gulp atmospheric air at the surface, an adaptation to shallow, low-oxygen water that can nearly dry up in the dry season. It is also why clear surface access is a physiological need, not a nice touch.
- Males build bubble nests out of saliva-coated air bubbles, with or without a female present. A healthy male will maintain and repair one purely on instinct.
- Wild bettas are plain. The vivid reds and blues are centuries of selective breeding; wild *Betta splendens* are a comparatively dull olive-brown.
- Their memory lasts months, not seconds. Bettas retain learned associations well enough to recognize a specific person's approach at feeding time.

Tank, heater & filter

Five gallons is the current standard minimum for one betta, and bigger is genuinely easier rather than just more generous: temperature and water chemistry swing less in more water, which means fewer sudden stresses on the fish. Use a lid, bettas are surprisingly good jumpers. The three pieces of equipment below are the setup. Everything else is decor.



Minimum 5 gallons for one betta, cycled before the fish goes in
No sharp plastic decor. Stiff plastic plants tear fins, which is a real and common injury.

NEVER

Keep a betta in an unheated, unfiltered bowl. This is a tropical fish, and cold water suppresses immune function and digestion. The bowl is the single most common cause of the problems in Section 03.

What the diagram doesn't show

- The filter has to be gentle. A power filter's outflow that a tetra barely notices will exhaust a betta and shred its fins over time, which is exactly why sponge filters became the default recommendation for this species.
- Cover increases activity rather than reducing it. A fish with somewhere to retreat to is more willing to be in open water, covered in the research on page 9.
- Cycle the tank before the fish, not after. That is page 7, and it is the part that takes weeks rather than an afternoon.

Water parameters that actually matter

PARAMETER	TARGET	WHY IT MATTERS
Temperature	78 to 80°F	Tropical fish; cold water suppresses immune function and digestion
Acceptable temperature band	76 to 82°F	Stability beats hitting an exact number; avoid rapid swings
pH	6.5 to 7.5	Wide tolerance, up to about 7.8; stability matters more than the value
Ammonia	0 ppm	Even 0.25 ppm causes gill damage; any reading is an emergency
Nitrite	0 ppm	Blocks oxygen uptake in the blood; toxic at any measurable level
Nitrate	Under 20 ppm	Byproduct of a healthy cycle; controlled with regular water changes

Zero is not the same as low

Ammonia and nitrite have a target of zero, not "low." Unlike temperature or pH there is no safe nonzero baseline for either, and a cycled, established tank reads exactly 0 ppm for both, consistently. If either shows a reading, that is the problem, whatever else the fish looks like.

Test with liquid reagents

Not paper strips, which are notoriously imprecise. A liquid-reagent kit is the only reliable way to know whether a tank is cycled before a fish goes in, and it is a one-time, reusable purchase.

Treat every drop of tap water

Use a dechlorinator rated for chlorine *and* chloramine. Many municipal systems use chloramine specifically because it doesn't evaporate off, so a chlorine-only product won't fully neutralize it.

Does hardness (GH and KH) matter?

Less than the five above, but it is not irrelevant. GH measures dissolved minerals; KH measures the water's ability to resist pH swings. Bettas tolerate a wide range of both, but very soft, poorly buffered water, common with reverse-osmosis or heavily filtered tap water, can let pH crash suddenly after a water change. That is far more stressful than a stable pH slightly outside the ideal band. If low KH shows up alongside unstable pH between water changes, a small consistent dose of a buffering product fixes it. Get ammonia, nitrite, and temperature right first.

THE ONE NUMBER PEOPLE TREAT AS OPTIONAL

Temperature. It gets read as decor rather than chemistry, but cold water slows a betta's metabolism and immune response, which means it takes longer to recover from even minor ammonia or nitrite exposure. A heater holding a steady 78 to 80°F is what makes every other parameter on this page more forgiving.

Cycling, water changes & maintenance

You are not just diluting mess when you change water, you are managing a nitrogen cycle. Beneficial bacteria convert toxic ammonia from waste and uneaten food into nitrite, then into far less harmful nitrate. In an uncycled tank those colonies don't exist yet, and ammonia has nowhere to go but up. This is why bettas so often decline in the first two weeks of a brand new tank: it looks clean, but the biological filtration hasn't established.

Fishless cycling, start to finish

STAGE	WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
Week 1 to 2	Ammonia rises	Keep dosing an ammonia source; test every 1 to 2 days
Week 2 to 4	Ammonia falls, nitrite spikes	Keep testing; do not add the fish yet
Week 4 to 6	Nitrite falls, nitrate appears	Cycle is finishing; confirm before adding the fish
Ready	Ammonia and nitrite both 0 for a full week	Water change, then add the betta

The whole process typically takes 4 to 6 weeks without a fish in the tank, which is why buying the tank weeks before the fish is the single best decision in this package.

Ongoing water changes

A 20 to 30% water change weekly, using a gravel vacuum to pull waste out of the substrate. Partial is the point: a full change strips out the beneficial bacteria that keeps the tank stable and effectively restarts the cycle. Match the new water's temperature before it goes in, and treat it with conditioner first, not after.

NEVER RINSE FILTER MEDIA UNDER THE TAP

The bacteria colony lives on it, and chlorinated tap water kills it. Rinse sponge or bio-media in a bucket of old tank water pulled during the water change, and never replace all the media at once.

Testing schedule

- **New or recently set up tanks:** ammonia and nitrite every 1 to 2 days until both read zero consistently for at least a week.
- **Established, cycled tanks:** weekly, and immediately any time the betta seems off. Clamped fins, lethargy, or loss of appetite usually show up in the water before they show up as a visible symptom.
- **After any water change over 30%:** a quick recheck confirms the new water didn't introduce chlorine or chloramine.

What causes a spike in a tank that was previously fine: overfeeding, over-cleaning the filter, or a sudden jump in bioload such as adding another fish without re-cycling.

Diet & feeding

Bettas are obligate carnivores and surface ambush feeders, taking insects, larvae, and small crustaceans off the water's surface in the wild. Overfeeding, not underfeeding, is the far more common mistake in captivity.

STAGE	FREQUENCY	PORTION
Adult	Once or twice daily, plus one fasting day a week	2 to 4 pellets per meal, or whatever clears in about 60 seconds
Juvenile	2 to 3 times daily	Smaller portions, same 60-second rule
Fry, weeks 3 to 4	3 to 4 times daily	Small meals, dropping in frequency as they grow
Fry, free-swimming	4 to 5 small meals daily	Infusoria first, then progressively larger foods

THE PORTION RULE WORTH MEMORIZING

A betta's stomach is roughly the size of its own eyeball. That is the actual basis for the standard "2 to 4 pellets" guidance, and it is why a fish that looks eager for more is not necessarily a fish that needs more.

What belongs in the tank

Staple

A betta-specific high-protein pellet, not tropical flakes or goldfish pellets, which carry the wrong nutrient profile and more filler. Look for dried brine shrimp, krill, or fish meal near the top of the ingredient list, and roughly 30% protein or higher. Pre-soak pellets that expand in water.

Treats, 1 to 3 times a week

Frozen, freeze-dried, or live bloodworms, brine shrimp, daphnia, tubifex worms, mysis shrimp, and mosquito larvae. Bloodworms are rich enough to limit to 1 to 2 times a week, 1 to 2 worms per meal. Rehydrate freeze-dried food first, feeding it dry raises constipation risk.

NEVER FEED

Bread, onion, garlic, salt, sugary foods, processed meats, citrus, or dairy. Bread swells and adds nothing; onion and garlic carry toxic sulfur compounds; citrus is acidic enough to crash tank pH and burn gills; bettas are effectively lactose intolerant. General tropical flakes are not an appropriate staple either.

Remove what isn't eaten

Uneaten food breaks down into ammonia, which is the most common cause of a spike in a tank that was previously stable. Net out anything left after a few minutes. A blanched, shelled pea now and then works as a constipation remedy, but it is a remedy, not a regular food.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Buying the bowl-and-fish kit, which leaves out the two pieces of equipment that matter most: the heater and a gentle filter.
- Adding the fish to an uncycled tank, then blaming the decline on a weak fish rather than on ammonia.
- Overfeeding, which produces bloating, swim bladder problems, and the fouled water behind most ammonia spikes.
- Doing a full water change to "really clean it," which strips the bacteria colony and restarts the cycle.
- Rinsing filter media under the tap, same outcome by a different route.
- Using stiff plastic plants and sharp decor, a real and common cause of torn fins.
- Reading a still, hidden betta in a bare tank as a calm one, when that is exactly the pattern restricted, bare conditions produce.

BETTAS ARE THE BEST-STUDIED FISH IN THE HOBBY

One study in *Animal Welfare* found that space and environmental enrichment both affect behavior in *Betta splendens*, with restricted space raising hiding and inactivity. A second examined tank size and furnishings. A third found fish in aquaria planted with *Sagittaria subulata* showed the longest average active swimming time and fewer negative behaviors. Cover makes a betta more willing to use open water, not less.

Enrichment, by priority

1. Tank volume

Decided before anything goes in it. Larger tanks promoted natural, active behavior in the space research; restricted conditions produced the hiding and inactivity pattern.

3. Surface resting spots

Bettas are labyrinth fish and surface breathers. Broad-leaved plants and a leaf hammock give them somewhere to rest near the air they actually use.

5. Tannins and softened light

Driftwood releases tannins, softening the light and moving the tank closer to the blackwater conditions the species comes from.

2. Dense planting and cover

Live planting works on two axes, cover plus water quality and microbial community. If you use artificial plants, choose soft ones; stiff plastic tears fins.

4. Varied feeding

Move the feeding point around rather than dropping food in the same corner daily, and vary the food itself. The cheapest item on this list.

6. Mirrors, at the bottom or off it

Researchers use the mirror-image test to provoke a threat display so they can measure the stress response afterward. It is a stress test, not a toy.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to check before you medicate.

ACT TODAY IF YOU SEE
Any detectable ammonia or nitrite reading · raised, pinecone-like scales · a fine gold or rust dusty sheen over the body · white grains across the body and fins with scratching · fins going ragged or discolored · gasping at the surface beyond normal air-gulping · sudden loss of color with clamped fins · refusal to eat past 5 to 7 days

Test the water first, every time

Almost every common betta illness traces back to water quality or water temperature, which is genuinely good news: the first response to a sick betta is nearly always the same. Test ammonia, nitrite, nitrate, and temperature before you buy a single medication. A large share of what looks like disease is a chemistry problem the fish is reacting to, and medicating on top of bad water treats the symptom while the cause keeps running.

What to have written down

- ☐ Current ammonia, nitrite, and nitrate readings, with the test date
- ☐ Current temperature, and whether the heater holds it steady
- ☐ Date and size of the last water change
- ☐ How long the tank has been running, and whether it was cycled
- ☐ What and how much you feed, and when the fish last ate
- ☐ Anything added recently: fish, plants, decor, or medication

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Gulping air at the surface, a labyrinth fish doing what it evolved to do	Gasping at the surface constantly, especially with rapid gill movement
Resting on a leaf or the substrate after lights out	Lying on the bottom during the day with clamped fins and faded color
Building and repairing a bubble nest with no female present	Sudden loss of interest in food and surroundings over a day or two
Flaring briefly at a reflection or a passing shadow	Continuous flaring with no let-up, usually a mirror or a tankmate problem

Fin rot, ich & velvet

Fin rot

Cause: a bacterial infection, almost always following poor water quality, physical fin damage from sharp decor or strong current, or prolonged stress. **Signs:** frayed, ragged, or discolored fin edges that recede over days. **Response:** clean water first, then aquarium salt for mild cases, adding antibiotics if it is more advanced or not improving. **Recovery:** fins regrow once the water is right, though regrowth can come back a slightly different color. Fin rot that keeps returning is a water quality problem, not a treatment problem.

Ich (white spot disease)

Cause: the parasite *Ichthyophthirius multifiliis*, usually introduced on new fish, plants, or water. **Signs:** small white grains scattered across the body and fins, plus scratching against decor. **Response:** gradually raise the tank temperature, which speeds the parasite's life cycle into the stage that treatment can reach, alongside a copper or formalin-based medication. An adjustable heater makes the temperature change controllable, which is the part people get wrong.

Velvet

Cause: *Oodinium*, a parasite. **Signs:** a fine gold or rust-colored dusty sheen over the body, often easiest to see with a flashlight at an angle, alongside clamped fins and lethargy. **Response:** darken the tank, since the parasite is partly light-dependent, and use an antiparasitic or copper treatment. **Urgency:** this one moves fast and can be fatal quickly, so early treatment matters more here than anywhere else on this page.

QUARANTINE IS CHEAPER THAN TREATMENT

Ich and velvet are introduced, not spontaneous. A quarantine period for any new fish, and a rinse and inspection for new plants, prevents most of what this page describes. If you keep more than one tank, keep separate nets and equipment.

THE COMMON THREAD

All three take hold far more easily in a fish whose immune system is already suppressed by cold water or ammonia exposure. A stable, heated, cycled tank is not a guarantee, but it is the difference between an exposure and an infection.

Swim bladder, dropsy & columnaris

Swim bladder disorder

Cause: usually overfeeding, constipation, or infection, and occasionally a rapid temperature drop. **Signs:** buoyancy problems, floating at the surface, sinking to the bottom, or swimming at odd angles. **Response:** fast the fish for 2 to 3 days, which resolves many mild cases, then offer a single cooked, de-shelled pea to help things move along. **Prevention:** the portion rule on page 8. This is the condition most directly caused by feeding too much.

Dropsy

What it is: not really a single disease. Raised, pinecone-like scales are the visible result of fluid building up inside the fish from organ failure. **Signs:** the pinecone look, usually clearest viewed from above, alongside a swollen belly and lethargy. **Reality check:** by the time that sign appears the underlying problem is usually advanced, and the prognosis is often poor. Treat the tank conditions, keep the fish comfortable, and be realistic about the outcome.

Columnaris

Cause: the bacterium *Flavobacterium columnare*, notable for being highly contagious between fish. **Signs:** pale, fuzzy or saddle-shaped patches, often around the mouth or along the back, with rapid progression. **Response:** antibacterial treatment and isolation. If you keep more than one tank, do not share nets, siphons, or hands between them without washing.

MYCOBACTERIOSIS, WORTH KNOWING ABOUT

Fish tuberculosis is rare, but it is zoonotic, transmissible to people through contact with infected water, especially through broken skin. Wear gloves for tank maintenance if you have open cuts, and particularly on a tank where something unexplained is going wrong.

BEFORE YOU REACH FOR MEDICATION

Test and correct water quality and temperature. A huge share of betta illness resolves, or never happens at all, from keeping the tank properly heated, filtered, and on a consistent water-change schedule. Aquatic vets exist for genuinely serious or unclear cases, but they are the exception rather than the norm in betta care.

Stress, aggression & tankmates

Reading a betta instead of touching it

You do not handle this fish. A betta's slime coat is an active barrier against infection and parasites, and bare hands strip it away on contact, so moves happen by net or cup only. That makes reading condition from a distance the real skill. **Stress signs:** lethargy, fins clamped tightly against the body, faded color, loss of appetite, hiding, and rapid gill movement. Almost all of them trace back to water quality or a temperature that has drifted, not to anything you did by hand. **A healthy betta** shows vibrant color, intact flowing fins, normal activity, and eager interest in food.

Bringing a new betta home

Float the sealed bag in the tank for about 15 minutes so temperature equalizes gradually, then net the fish out into the tank rather than pouring the bag's water in with it. Store water can introduce contaminants or throw off your chemistry. Add one fish at a time, and watch parameters for a day or two after any addition. Avoid tapping the glass, and keep the tank away from constant foot traffic and vibration.

The mirror question

Mirrors are sold as exercise. In research they are used as a stress test: the mirror-image test is a standard way to provoke a threat display, with cortisol used to measure the response afterward. Brief exposure is occasionally suggested as exercise, but the honest framing is that you are triggering a threat response on purpose, which puts it at the bottom of the enrichment list on page 9, or off it entirely.

Tankmates and cohabitation

The standard advice is that males are housed alone, and for a fish you bought as an adult that stands. The research is more interesting than the rule suggests: bettas of either sex can be group-housed with lower aggression *if they have been housed in groups since hatching under enriched conditions*, and a separate study found the timing of isolation from an enriched environment determines later aggression and sexual maturity.

WHAT THAT RESEARCH DOES NOT SAY

It is not permission to put two adult males together. Aggression in this species is partly a rearing outcome rather than a fixed trait, which means the aggression your betta shows you was shaped before you bought it. Nothing about that changes what happens when two adults raised separately share a tank.

Setup checklist & water targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 5 gallon minimum tank, larger is easier to keep stable
- ☐ 15 to 25 W adjustable heater
- ☐ Sponge or other low-flow filter
- ☐ Dechlorinator rated for chlorine and chloramine
- ☐ Substrate, plus live or soft silk plants
- ☐ Betta-specific high-protein pellets
- ☐ Lid or hood, bettas jump
- ☐ Thermometer, separate from the heater's own dial
- ☐ Liquid-reagent test kit, not paper strips
- ☐ Gravel vacuum and a dedicated bucket
- ☐ Cave hide and a surface leaf hammock
- ☐ Net or cup for transfers, never bare hands

Water targets

TARGET	RANGE
Temperature, ideal	78 to 80°F
Temperature, acceptable band	76 to 82°F
pH	6.5 to 7.5, stability over the exact value
Ammonia	0 ppm
Nitrite	0 ppm
Nitrate	Under 20 ppm
Weekly water change	20 to 30%

Before your betta comes home

- ☐ Tank cycled: ammonia and nitrite at 0 for a full week
- ☐ Heater holding a steady temperature for 24 to 48 hours
- ☐ Filter running with flow gentle enough not to push the fish
- ☐ Plants and decor checked by hand for sharp edges
- ☐ Conditioner and test kit already on the shelf
- ☐ Lid fitted, with no gaps a fish could clear

Emergency & quick targets

ACT TODAY IF

Ammonia or nitrite reads above 0 · raised pinecone-like scales · a gold or rust dusty film over the body · white grains plus scratching · fins going ragged · constant gasping with rapid gill movement · faded color with clamped fins · no food taken for 5 to 7 days

READING	TARGET
Temperature	78 to 80°F (band 76 to 82°F)
Ammonia	0 ppm, no exceptions
Nitrite	0 ppm, no exceptions
Nitrate	Under 20 ppm
pH	6.5 to 7.5
Weekly water change	20 to 30%, gravel vacuumed
Feeding	2 to 4 pellets, once or twice daily
Fasting day	One per week

FIRST RESPONSE TO ALMOST ANYTHING

Test ammonia, nitrite, nitrate, and temperature. Do a 25% water change with conditioned, temperature-matched water. Stop feeding for a day. Then decide whether you are looking at a disease or at a chemistry problem the fish is reacting to.

EMERGENCY AMMONIA RESPONSE

If ammonia or nitrite is detectable: partial water change now, stop feeding, do not clean the filter, and retest daily until both read zero. Adding a bacterial supplement helps; adding medication usually does not.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
The fish itself	\$5 to \$30 (up to about \$55 for rare varieties)
Tank, 5 gallons or larger	Biggest line item, varies by size and brand
Lid or hood	Often included; confirm before you buy the tank
Adjustable heater, 15 to 25 W	Priced by wattage and quality
Sponge filter	The gentle, low-flow standard for this species
Thermometer	Small one-time cost, worth having separately
Liquid-reagent test kit	One-time, reusable, and non-negotiable
Water conditioner	Small ongoing cost per bottle
Gravel vacuum and bucket	One-time
Substrate, plants, hide, and leaf hammock	Modest, and where you can economize
Total initial setup	\$100 to \$300
Food (annual)	\$30 to \$50
Conditioner, test reagents, and electricity (monthly)	Most of the ongoing spend
Monthly ongoing	\$20 to \$30
Annual total, typical	\$100 to \$250

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The heater and the test kit. The heater is what makes every other water parameter more forgiving, and the test kit is the only way to know whether the tank is cycled at all. Save on decor and substrate before you save here.

THE \$50 THAT CHANGES THE OUTCOME

Spending the extra \$50 to \$100 upfront on a real 5 gallon tank with a heater instead of a bowl kit is the difference between a fish that struggles and one that thrives, and it barely moves the long-term cost picture either way.

First 30 days checklist

Day one here is the day the fish arrives, not the day the tank does.

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm ammonia and nitrite still read 0 after the fish went in
- ☐ Check temperature daily; a new heater is the most likely thing to drift
- ☐ Feed lightly and remove anything uneaten within a few minutes
- ☐ Leave the fish alone otherwise: no rearranging, no tapping, no mirror

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ First 20 to 30% water change, conditioned and temperature-matched
- ☐ Test ammonia, nitrite, and nitrate weekly and write the numbers down
- ☐ Settle into a feeding routine, including one fasting day a week
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 20

Week 4

- ☐ Review the log for drift in temperature or a creeping nitrate reading
- ☐ Add planting or cover if the tank is still sparse, one change at a time
- ☐ Rinse the filter sponge in old tank water, never under the tap
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 21

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Confirm the tank is holding a stable cycle without weekly intervention
- ☐ Vary feeding location and food type on the schedule from page 21
- ☐ Watch fin edges closely: early fin rot is easiest to reverse
- ☐ Look back at the log for slow trends rather than single readings

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Frayed, ragged, or receding fins	Fin rot, or fin damage from decor or flow	Test water, clean water first (page 11)
White grains on body and fins, scratching	Ich	Raise temperature gradually, medicate (page 11)
Gold or rust dusty sheen	Velvet	Darken tank, treat early, moves fast (page 11)
Floating, sinking, or swimming at odd angles	Swim bladder disorder	Fast 2 to 3 days, then a shelled pea (page 12)
Raised, pinecone-like scales	Dropsy, organ failure	Poor prognosis; correct conditions (page 12)
Pale fuzzy or saddle-shaped patches	Columnaris	Isolate and treat, highly contagious (page 12)
Clamped fins, faded color, lethargy	Water quality or temperature	Test everything before medicating (page 10)
Constant gasping, rapid gill movement	Ammonia or nitrite exposure	Partial water change now, retest (page 15)
Not eating, otherwise normal	Stress, pickiness, or cold water	Check temperature, try another food (page 8)
Not eating past 5 to 7 days	Several possible causes	Investigate; bring the Owner Log (page 20)
Bloated belly, stringy or absent waste	Overfeeding or constipation	Fast, then reduce portions (page 8)

Daily & weekly routine

Daily

- ☐ Check the temperature reading
- ☐ Feed 2 to 4 pellets, once or twice, and remove anything uneaten
- ☐ Quick visual check: fins, color, gill movement, activity
- ☐ Confirm the surface is clear so the fish can reach air

Weekly

- ☐ Test ammonia, nitrite, and nitrate, and log the numbers
- ☐ 20 to 30% water change with a gravel vacuum
- ☐ Treat replacement water with conditioner and match its temperature
- ☐ One fasting day, no food at all
- ☐ Vary the feeding location or offer a treat food

Monthly

- ☐ Rinse the filter sponge in old tank water pulled during a change
- ☐ Wipe algae from the glass and trim or thin overgrown plants
- ☐ Run a hand over decor and plants, checking for sharp edges
- ☐ Review the log for slow trends rather than single readings

Occasionally

- ☐ Check the heater still holds its set point rather than trusting the dial
- ☐ Replace test kit reagents before they expire
- ☐ Reposition or add one piece of cover to refresh the layout

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	TEMP °F	AMMONIA	NITRITE	NITRATE	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

Water chemistry is invisible until the fish reacts to it. A written record turns a nitrate reading that has crept up over six weeks into something you can actually see, and it is the single most useful thing to have in front of you when something goes wrong.

Water change log

DATE	AMOUNT CHANGED	NOTES

Treatment log

DATE	SYMPTOM & TREATMENT	OUTCOME

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ Tank volume decided first, before anything goes in it
- ☐ Dense planting, live where possible, soft silk if artificial
- ☐ Surface resting spots: broad leaves or a leaf hammock
- ☐ Driftwood or decor breaking the tank into zones and sightlines
- ☐ At least one enclosed hide the fish can fully enter

Monthly review

- ☐ Move the feeding point rather than using the same corner every day
- ☐ Vary the food itself, rotating a treat food into the week
- ☐ Reposition or add one piece of cover, without blocking the surface
- ☐ Check whether the fish is using more of the tank than last month, not less

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't run mirror sessions as a routine, what you are provoking is a threat display. Don't use stiff plastic plants, which tear fins. Don't read a still, hidden betta in a bare tank as a relaxed one. And don't treat a heater and filter as optional extras: no amount of enrichment compensates for unstable water.

Enrichment log

DATE	CHANGE MADE	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Labyrinth organ	The structure that lets a betta breathe atmospheric air at the surface, an adaptation to low-oxygen water.
Slime coat	The protective mucus layer on a fish's skin, an active barrier against infection and parasites. Bare hands strip it.
Nitrogen cycle	The bacterial process converting ammonia to nitrite, then nitrite to far less harmful nitrate.
Cycling	Establishing those bacteria colonies before a fish goes in, typically 4 to 6 weeks fishless.
Bioload	The total waste output a tank has to process. Adding fish or overfeeding raises it.
Bio-media	The filter surfaces the bacteria colony lives on. Never rinse it under the tap.
Dechlorinator	Water conditioner that neutralizes chlorine and chloramine in tap water.
GH / KH	General hardness (dissolved minerals) and carbonate hardness (buffering capacity, the resistance to pH swings).
Flaring	Spreading the gills and fins in a threat display. Brief flaring is normal; continuous flaring is not.
Bubble nest	A raft of saliva-coated bubbles a male builds and maintains on instinct, with or without a female present.
Zoonotic	Transmissible from animal to human. Relevant here only to mycobacteriosis, which is rare.

Compiled from veterinary and aquarium sources, including the peer-reviewed betta welfare research cited on pages 9 and 13, and cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for an aquatic veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

© Beastly Facts · Version 1.0 · September 2026